

Literature Review:

The Effect of Documentary Film on Library Stakeholders' Impression of Librarianship

Amanda M. Clark

Morgridge College of Education, University of Denver

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Introduction

In the library and information services field, phrases like “countering censorship campaigns,” and “fighting for the freedom to read” are often used. These strong sentiments are necessary always and especially in this climate of book ban culture wars. However, there is a gap in the literature as to any well-researched, proactive programs a community can use to prevent the mistreatment of librarians throughout the book challenge lifecycle. The reactive nature of library policy and censorship mitigation services have not been enough to preclude those who feel impassioned about book removal from persecuting librarians. The author’s idea to use the 2025 documentary film *The Librarians* as a platform for a mistreatment prevention program was born from a notable deficiency in prevention initiatives. This literature review will explore the themes the author examined to gain insights into how creating a dialogue around the issue of librarian mistreatment through the use of documentary film may impact library stakeholders’ impression of librarianship.

Review of Literature

Mistreatment and Reactive Response

The Office for Intellectual Freedom (OIF) has been collecting data on book challenges and censorship attempts for over two decades. In 2021, a significant spike in the number of unique book titles challenged in the United States was recorded (American Library Association, 2023). Since this spike, researchers and journalists like Marlaina Cockcroft have been collecting regional data on how librarians are adversely affected by book challenges. In her survey research, Cockcroft’s (2023) findings report that 24% of librarians have experienced book or display related harassment. Some examples of this mistreatment include social media attacks; vilifying librarians by calling them pedophiles; threats of violence, including violence toward librarians’ family members; ongoing libel resulting in PTSD; and lack

of help from antagonistic school administration. A shocking 34% of survey respondents reported that they have considered leaving their jobs as a result (p.34).

The American Library Association (ALA) has had a long-standing commitment to librarians facing a whole host of censorship related issues. The OIF, the ALA, and other affiliated non-profit organizations such as the Freedom to Read Foundation (FTRF), as well as unaffiliated non-profit organizations such as the National Coalition Against Censorship (NCAC) have offered various forms of support including legal aid, confidential counseling, and financial assistance to librarians who find themselves in precarious situations. These organizations have also offered librarians training, toolkits, and resource center assistance to implement policies and set up guardrails that respond to book challenges. While policy formation itself is proactive, the measures that result and the other non-profit services mentioned are all reactive in nature; they are subsequent to a book challenge.

Dichotomous Data and Its Underlying Reasons

What informs the layperson's understanding of why it would or would not be permissible to persecute librarians over the status of a book? That is a difficult question to answer without factual research data. The Every Library Institute has not collected data on this specific question but has collected and analyzed data on how librarians are perceived by those outside of the profession, general attitudes toward book bans, and parent perceptions of libraries and librarians. Their findings indicate that most people trust librarians to make selection decisions, that parents think libraries are safe places, that people should be able to read freely, that diverse books are essential, that banning books is "a waste of time," and that book bans infringe on parents' rights to make decisions with their children (Every Library Institute 2025; Every Library Institute, 2024). Yet, librarians in the United States have cited the rise in incivility around censorship issues as a reason they want to leave the profession (Sharp et al.,

2024). This dichotomy indicates a superficial understanding of the First Amendment and an erosion of civil responsibility.

As a former student of criminal justice, it would be disingenuous to ignore the fact that it is difficult to understand the First Amendment as its evolution includes interpretation and nuance. Ross (2024) states that “while it might seem a simple proposition that removing books from school libraries based on their content always violates the First Amendment, the governing law is far more complex” (p. 1675). Due to this complexity, it is not surprising that individuals who have not studied constitutional law or are not professional librarians may not be aware of the true weight of the issue, be concerned by the unprecedented number of recent book challenges, or be bothered by the fact that book bans are becoming normalized (Baêta et al., 2025). Historical debates on the constitutionality of book banning are typically divided into only two parties, pro-censorship and anti-censorship. This makes sense as the nature of debate is structured around opposing viewpoints but it is the author’s assertion that this division of stance is currently insufficient to maintain civility within libraries. An ongoing dialogue within all library stakeholder communities needs to occur that not only explains the professional ethics of librarians but also highlights the distinctions between the civil, moral, legal, and logical implications and outcomes of book bans.

The professional ethics librarians learn in their degree programs squarely position them in the anti-censorship party. Librarians are taught that, in order to help maintain a functioning democracy, they must protect intellectual freedom by upholding the rights afforded to all people within the United States by the First Amendment. Librarians are also taught to build collections that include diverse voices and to intentionally seek materials that reflect various ethnicities, cultures, and marginalized groups. However, the fact that libraries operate this way is not widely known. It is not explicitly taught to American school children nor is it widely advertised to the general public. In their research about what librarians wish the

public understood about censorship, Clark Hunt et al. (2025) revealed that librarians want the public to better understand the way libraries function and that universal access to information is essential. Within this inclusive vein exists the opportunity to invite community members to the table to discuss the mistreatment of librarians resulting from book ban rhetoric.

The Rhetoric of Book Bans and a Social Psychology Framework

A substantial portion of the ethical arguments in favor of book bans revolve around the issue of parental rights. Ross (2024) explains that the parental-rights movement is not new and was largely influenced by the right-wing politics of Michael Farris. Farris, a conservative Christian lawyer, carefully orchestrated the movement and following his story can help us understand the surge in targeted book removals (p. 1703). The formation of vociferous special interest groups followed Farris' efforts to codify parental rights. Organizations such as Moms for Liberty, Citizens Defending Freedom, and Parents' Rights in Education began forming social groups that politicize parental concern and particularly maternal concern (Bracewell & Daily, 2024). However, concern for the well-being of children is a universal issue and so too should be the systemic changes necessary to restore well-being to librarians. Concepts from social psychology may provide a lens into the formation of these groups.

Henri Tajfel was a social psychologist widely recognized for developing Social Identity Theory (SIT). His work sought to explain how natural it is for people to classify themselves into social groups, intertwine their identities with group identities, and compare the characteristics of their "ingroups" with the differing characteristics of those in "outgroups" who embrace alternate identities (Tajfel & Turner, 1979). Motivated by a desire to reduce uncertainty, this process results in the formation of opinions not based on personal experience but instead on degree of differentiation from the ingroup. Put another way, ingroup identification drives decision making rather than reason or knowledge (Song & Oh, 2025). When reading about this theory in the context of politically polarized issues like book bans, it stood out

as one possible explanation for why anyone who wouldn't normally mistreat a professional would be willing to mistreat a librarian. In critically analyzing how SIT might explain the mistreatment of librarians, a pattern of events can be discerned. Rather than seeking information from librarians about *why* certain books with challenging topics are found in the stacks, a struggle with identity or a moral panic informed by the book removal ingroup's ideal of what childhood *should* look like or how society *should* function is observed.

What Kind of Research Might Help?

To address the mistreatment of librarians and the dichotomy between public support for libraries and rhetoric fueled book ban attempts in the form of a new research study, the author was drawn to Brenda Dervin's Sense Making methodologies. Dervin, a leader in the fields of communication and library and information science, lends the following perspective, "dialogic or communication theory of communication focuses not on homogenizing difference but on putting difference into dialogue and thus using it to assist human sense-making" (Dervin & Huesca, 2001/2003). Agarwal (2012) explains this more plainly, "Sense-Making is all about trying to reconcile apparent differences and polarities without wishing away the differences, but recognizing them as important" (para. 9). Accordingly, any research study that aims to explore the feasibility of a program intended to help communities find common ground with librarians despite book ban polarity should use dialogue rather than simply viewing the study's subjects as devoid of information, transmitting that information via a film screening, and collecting only quantitative data about any attitude shifts. Subsequently, the research study proposal to follow will include the observation of a discussion about the themes of the film. Importantly, questions to stakeholders must be designed to welcome and support the sharing of each individual's full perspective to help improve outcomes for librarians. Using Dervin's methodologies to better assess post

film screening impressions will allow the research to more carefully examine the perspectives of community members who do not neatly fall into the pro-censorship and anti-censorship categories.

Documentary Films on Social Issues and Their Impact

The use of documentary films as an impetus for social awareness and change is well researched in the United States and abroad. Following the release of films such as *An Inconvenient Truth*, *Fahrenheit 9/11*, *Food Inc.*, *Sicko*, and *Supersize Me*, Nisbet and Aufderheide (2009) addressed the need for focused inquiry on the social impact of documentary films. In their essay, they point out that documentaries have evolved from purely informational films into catalysts for debate, policy change, and community advocacy. The transformative power of these films is not inherently unethical because their creators aim to educate, raise awareness, and inspire large audiences. Crucially, the ethical decisions that documentary filmmakers face mirror those of librarians. The authors of the aforementioned essay explained that documentary filmmakers consider ethical decision making a fundamental part of their artistry and that they experience immense pressure to achieve greater results with small budgets. Documentarians abide by principles such as “do no harm,” “protect the vulnerable,” and “honor the viewer’s trust” all while seeking to illuminate a “higher truth” (Nisbet & Aufderheide, 2009).

Documentary films are, in and of themselves, an exercise in intellectual freedom. In a case study about the film *Food, Inc.*, Flowers and Swan (2011) pointed out that films can be used in the analysis of social issues in various ways including reflecting on how they are received by audiences, how they promote knowledge creation, and how they transform our understanding of the world around us. Moreover, the authors explain that when films influence social movements, the discussion around them may reveal that even conventional wisdom deserves further examination to discover additional context. In addition to using documentaries to analyze social issues, Pietri et al. (2024) demonstrated that the use of documentary films can be a cost-effective and readily scalable online training tool, especially for

organizations that lack the funding to develop in-person programs. Through collaboration with the creators of the film *Picture a Scientist*, Pietri et al. performed two large-scale field studies intended to determine whether this documentary film about the negative effects of sexism in STEM had the potential to change viewer's perspectives and intentions. In the first study, using controlled experiments, researchers found that the combination of strong narratives and expert interviews enhanced awareness of sexism in STEM. Further applying that knowledge, the second quasi-experimental study found that:

Compared to those who had not watched the film (but intended to), participants who had viewed the film indicated higher awareness of gender bias, stronger intentions to address this bias, and participants in leadership reported stronger intentions to enact inclusive policies (for example, making it easier to report mistreatment). (Pietri et al, 2024, p. 1)

The above quote, digested in its entirety, suggests that a pilot study on the effects of the 2025 documentary film *The Librarians* on library stakeholders' impressions of librarianship is a worthwhile endeavor as it specifically addresses the mistreatment of a professional group of individuals.

Conclusion

Film screenings in careful combination with "bias-literacy" discussions that make people feel more knowledgeable about book bans, library processes and policies, and promote positive intergroup contact can be an effective way to address the abuse and neglect that librarians across the country are currently experiencing. A related impact strategy may already be underway as the ALA has promoted the 2025 documentary film *The Librarians* on their website (American Library Association, 2025). The librarians featured in the film are affiliated with the ALA and the American Association of School Librarians (AASL) and the film highlights their struggles. A research pilot study designed to take into consideration the reactive nature of library policy, the dichotomy between how people think about

librarianship and the mistreatment of librarians, the rhetorical and psychological frameworks that may explain this mistreatment, and the potential impact of documentary film will help to measure the feasibility of a dialogic intervention intended to inspire change. If we cannot resolve our differences over book bans in the present, we may still be able to care for librarians in the immediate future.

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